

IOT is not an IT INITIATIVE, but a BUSINESS FUNCTION

By now, we all know what IoT is, but do we really know what to do with it? EFY tried to address this issue with some brainstorming sessions at Open Source India 2015 and IoT Show 2016. But we don't want to leave it at that. IoT is the agenda going forward, for many enterprises, but do they really know how to embrace it? **Diksha P. Gupta** from **Open Source For You** spoke to **R. Ravi vice-president, Research & Development, HCL Services Ltd.**, to figure out how best IoT can help organisations grow their businesses. Excerpts:

Q What is HCL's IoT strategy and in what way does the company see itself as the game changer in the IoT revolution?

It all started somewhere along with the 'Make in India' campaign, which the government is very keen about and a lot of private enterprises and corporates are also trying to embrace. From that perspective, we thought we could design and build cost-effective end-to-end solutions in the IoT space. Fortunately for us, we have already been operating in the systems integration space for many years, and we had a fantastic platform, or middleware, which we had developed on our own...we have earned IP rights for it. So we thought that it would make sense to build on that and support all the different types of sensors. HCL services have been focusing heavily on three-four industry verticals, including manufacturing, the health care and BFSI. While we do not have any tangible use case for IoT in BFSI, we are trying to focus on manufacturing, automotive, FMCG, logistics and healthcare from the IoT perspective.

Q IoT is clearly a big buzzword today, but is it anywhere close to reality, w.r.t. adoption, particularly in the sectors you are talking about?

Overall, I think people are just dabbling with the possible business solutions w.r.t. IoT, but I think the automotive industry has taken the lead, with telematics solutions that are already existing. Though these solutions were not called IoT earlier, now the industry is probably adding more features to them. Telematics was initially used for position tracking of the vehicle; now, more features linked to geo-fencing, fuel efficiency, driving behaviour, etc. are being added. That, we feel, will become very common in most of the vehicles going



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forward, in one or two years down the line. This is one sector in which we see the most traction. The second area in which we see IoT flourishing is that of medical devices. A lot of IoT based medical devices are proliferating in hospitals across Tier 2 and Tier 3 towns as well, apart from the Tier 1 towns.

Likewise, any high value equipment critical for the business environment, will be the next target where IoT will have a solid business case. We had already seen this in data centres in the IT area. Even the non-IT aspects of the data centre, like the AC, UPS systems, chillers, etc, have been using IoT. Though it was not called IoT earlier, it was the beginning of this trend. They wanted the environment to be up and running so that the data centres were always available. The same thing is getting extended to other critical equipment. One sector in which the value proposition will be very high is logistics, where users need to track and trail consignments in real-time. Probably this sector will start late but I think the uptake will be very high.

Q Could you explain what exactly you meant by IoT concepts being present in some of the sectors even prior to the IoT revolution, but not being referred to by this term.

It was not called IoT because it was not connected to the Internet. Now, with the cloud in place and Internet usage increasing, it is getting reoriented and is known as the IoT. With IoT coming in, the avenues are open for more stakeholders. For example, IoT has led to outsourcing, where the decision-makers are sitting outside the organisation.